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The City of K: Franz Kafka and Prague

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Taylor - Encircling Kafka: A Review of the City of K. - JCRT 3.3

Encircling Kafka? *The City of K.: Franz Kafka and Prague*

a review of "The City of K.: Franz Kafka and Prague," The Jewish Museum, New York, August 11, 2002 to January 5, 2003.

Victor Taylor
York College of Pennsylvania

August 17, 1921

*Esteemed Director: I am writing this letter in bed. I wanted to return to Prague on the 19th of this month, but I am afraid that it won't be possible. For several months I have been almost free of fever, but on Sunday I woke with a fever which climbed to over 38 degrees and still continues today. It's probably not the result of a cold, but one of those chance things common to lung disease which one cannot avoid. The doctor who examined me and found my lungs to be in good condition except for a stubborn remnant considers this acute fever to have little significance.*¹

Kafka in 1923-24²

The City of K.: Franz Kafka and Prague is an ambitious and unsettling postmodern exhibition, with original documents, facsimiles, and materials relating to Franz Kafka's literary works, life, and cultural surroundings carefully presented in a series of thematically organized "districts": "The Primal Scene," "A Little 'Ravachol,'" "Life in a Circle," "The Civil Servant and the Artist," "The Theater of Purity," "The Constantly Postponed Marriages," "The God of Suffocation," "The Burrow," "The Endless Office," "The Castle," "In the Penal Colony," and "The Threshold." The alignment of such diverse items as photographs, audiovisual installations, letters, and music allow the exhibition space to simulate Kafka's or K.'s existential space by extending an opposition between surface and depth into the various aspects of the author's literary works and Jewish cultural life in early twentieth century Prague. Key passages from Kafka's diaries, novels, and short stories written in white block letters on dark, "muddy" walls, wooden pallets, or an ascending staircase leading nowhere interrupt the eye as one passes from exhibit to the next. Early on, photographs of the Old Town rest submerged on a rock bed against a wall length, portrait filled genealogy of the Kafka family. Of the several excerpts inaugurating the exhibit, a line from the "Third Octavo Notebook" seems to capture the spatial and existential tensions presented throughout the exhibition: "A cage went in search of a bird."

This is not a city. It is a fissure in the ocean bed of time, covered with stony rubble of burned-out dreams and passions, through which we as if in a diving bell take a walk. It is interesting, but after a time one loses one's breath.³

Prague doesn't let go. Of either of us. This old crone has claws. One has to yield, or else. We would have to set fire to it on two sides, at the Vyšehrad and at the Hradčany; then it would be possible for us to get away.⁴

¹See Sander L. Gilman (1995) *Franz Kafka: The Jewish Patient*. London/New York: Routledge, 265.

²Juan Insua, (2002) editor, *The City of K.: Franz Kafka and Prague*,. Barcelona: Centre de Cultura Contemporània de Barcelona/Institut d'Edicions de la Diputació de Barcelona, 131. Permission The Jewish Museum.

³Gustav Janouch's *Conversations with Kafka* quoted from *The City of K.*, 12.

⁴*The City of K.*, 48.

Audiovisual Traffic (Verkehr) ⁵

The Civil Servant and the Artist ⁶

Measures for the Prevention of Accidents ⁷

The Burrow ⁸

From the installation In the Penal Colony ⁹

Prague Castle ¹⁰

The Threshold ¹¹

The Exhibition catalogue contains several historical, biographical, and theoretical essays on Franz Kafka. In particular Mark M. Anderson's essay provides an analysis of Kafka's transformation of the modern. The Jewish Museum, 1109 Fifth Avenue at 92nd Street, New York, New York.

Notes

Victor Taylor is author of *Para/Inquiry: Postmodern Religion and Culture* (Routledge), *The Religious Pray*, *The Profane Swear: The Civil War Writings of Robert L. Drummond* (Davies Group Publishers) and editor of *The Encyclopedia of Postmodernism* (Routledge) and *Postmodernism: Critical Concepts* (Routledge). He is an assistant professor of comparative literature and humanities at York College of Pennsylvania and executive editor of the JCRT.

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⁵*The City of K.*, 130. Permission The Jewish Museum.

⁶*The City of K.*, 131. Permission The Jewish Museum.

⁷*The City of K.*, 55. Permission The Jewish Museum

⁸*The City of K.*, 130. Permission The Jewish Museum.

⁹*The City of K.*, 130. Permission The Jewish Museum.

¹⁰*The City of K.*, 131. Permission The Jewish Museum.

¹¹*The City of K.*, 131. Permission The Jewish Museum.